



THE STORY OF India's waning single-screen theatres is a dramatic one. What were once architectural heritage establishments—housing close to a thousand cinephiles at a time, who'd often show their admiration by throwing coins at the screen—have now become invisible, rusty structures; almost an eyesore in a cityscape dotted with swanky malls and glitzy multiplexes. Today, at a time when around 150 single-screen theatres are shutting down every year, the Hindi film industry, popularly known as Bollywood, seems to be in the middle of an identity crisis.

As per a recent Ficci-EY report on India's media and entertainment (M&E) sector, the decline in the revenues of single-screen theatres has been fuelled by their continued shutdown, primarily in the Hindi heartland, while films continue to be made for the upper class/multiplex audiences. This trend has ended up isolating

a large chunk of the cinema-hall audience, who are used to paying ₹50-70 to watch a film in the theatres, experts say. At a multiplex, this cost is three to four times more. The high ticket pricing at multiplexes allows Bollywood movies to earn profits in multiples, thus reducing their dependence on the hinterland audience.

Nearly 40-45 per cent of the lifetime box office collections of hit Bollywood films used to come from non-multiplex zones in India, according to various industry estimates. With single-screens dying and Bollywood's south Indian counterparts cornering the cash through dubbed versions, Hindi film producers have no other option than to rethink their content and distribution strategy.

Sitting in his seventh floor office in Mumbai's Andheri West, Pen India Chairman & MD Jayantilal Gada, 60, offers some context: "For the last 10 years, we were building multiplexes, that's why the films were reflective of that audience. Single-screen films (that target the lowest common denominator) were diminishing, and more multiplex films were being made in Bollywood. They forgot about the single-screen audience."

While Gada has backed recent hits like *Gangubai Kathiawadi* and Hindi-dubbed versions of *RRR* and *Vikram*, he has also seen losses on films such as *Attack*, *Jersey*, *Chehre*, and *Bell Bottom*, among others, in the last two years. "Attack clashed with *RRR*, while *Jersey* came opposite *KGF2*. Timing matters a lot. They should have been delayed but our partners had been waiting for two years to release, due to the pandemic," he adds. On the other hand, those who couldn't wait, had to go for an OTT release. "Around 20-30 Bollywood films had a digital premiere during the pandemic, and south Indian films didn't get that chance because OTT platforms preferred Hindi films. Regional films don't get that kind of premium," he explains.

Gada is right. According to media consulting firm Ormax Media, with few major Hindi releases during the pandemic years, Hindi cinema's share of box office collections fell from 44 per cent in FY19 to just 27 per cent in FY21. By the time theatres re-opened, there was nothing worthwhile for Bollywood to showcase compared to the south Indian films. Of course, later there were hits like *Bhool Bhulaiyaa 2* that raked in ₹262 crore, says IMDb data, while this year's biggest Hindi commercial success, *The Kashmir Files*, made ₹340 crore, globally.

Experts believe that in the past few years, Bollywood started losing its sheen, with the pandemic only aggravating it. "For many years, Hindi films have gone urbane and elitist. Down South, they tell the same tales in a way that a common man can understand and enjoy them. We really need to learn from them about how not to alienate anybody," says Akshaye Rathi, Director of Aashirwad Theatres, a Nagpur-based film exhibition and distribution business. He insists that Bollywood stars haven't marketed themselves well in south Indian markets. "Big studios like Yash Raj Films release their films like